



Venue overhaul: A worker installs new seating as JLN Stadium undergoes a makeover ahead of the global para showpiece. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

many such rooms in Delhi, but we managed," Singh says.

Inside the stadium, 20 of the 40 washrooms have been made fully accessible, with the rest semi-accessible. Lifts are being installed for wheelchair users, and an entire first-floor gallery has been reserved for up to 500 wheelchair-bound athletes and coaches. "A wheelchair athlete can sit anywhere," Singh stresses.

The scale of para athletics also makes the task unique. "In able-bodied competition, there are 48 events. In para athletics, there are 186 — over four times as many. And technically speaking, it's 100 times more complex because for every event and every disability, the rules and regulations are different," Singh points out.

This complexity extends to

Inclusive shift: "The change has been dramatic": Coach Satyapal Singh (right) on JLN Stadium's transformation for para athletes.

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officiating. Over the past year, nearly 180 technical officials have been trained, with 150 set to work at the World Championships. "For visually impaired athletes, for example, the length of the tether binding athlete to guide is strictly defined. Wheelchair racing has precise measurements. We've conducted six courses in the past six months, with national and international technical officers coming in to train our officials," Singh explains.

But the bigger question looms: will these improvements last beyond the Championships?

Indian sports infrastructure has often struggled with upkeep once the spotlight fades. Singh insists this time will be different. "I've coached para athletes here for two decades. At least 25 per cent

of those who train here are para athletes. After the Games, they will benefit from the same accessible gyms, toilets, and tracks. When people see these facilities, their perspective will change," he says.

For para-athletes like Asian Games and World Championships gold medallist Ekta Bhyan, the hope is that such changes spread nationwide. "It's a great start at JLN, but it's important that it doesn't stop there," she says.

Jhajharia echoes the sentiment. "This is just the beginning. When officials and administrators see how well JLN has been made accessible, they will ask, 'Why can't we do this too?'"

That, perhaps, will be the true legacy of the Para Athletics World Championships.

"Nehru Stadium has witnessed some of India's greatest sporting moments — the 1982 Asian Games, the Commonwealth Games. The Para Athletics World Championships will create new memories here," says Jhajharia.

